



spots shy of promotion. Work remained to realise the ISL dream.

"In our head, we were very clear: we will do what it takes to be champions on and off the pitch next season," Prithijit says.

The club signed players with recent European and ISL experience. In came Domi Berlanga, who had featured in the UEFA Europa Conference League qualifiers, and Iceland international Joni Kauko, who moved from ISL Shield winner Mohun Bagan.

To top it all, Habas (**right**), the ISL's most successful manager, came on board. Ten months later, Kashi was champion.

"We've managed to get promoted, which is very difficult because the I-League is a very tough competition due to its infrastructure, schedules and travel. We've achieved it, and now we have to maintain our identity and stay in the ISL," Habas said, in a conversation with *Sportstar*.

"I'm very grateful to him for taking up this challenge. When you have the recipe and you get the best chef, you get the best biryani," Prithijit adds.

But Kashi would soon discover that the recipe for success required a tedious 315-day wait before they could savour its reward.

From rightfully winning the title and physically lifting the trophy to finally playing in the ISL, more than twice the duration of an entire I-League season had passed.



Final verdict: A four-point deduction by the AIFF Appeal Committee briefly put Churchill Brothers on top after the final matchday last season. However, the Court of Arbitration for Sport later overturned the decision, restoring Inter Kashi as champion.

Pics: INTER KASHI MEDIA

A four-point deduction by the All India Football Federation's (AIFF) Appeal Committee briefly made Churchill Brothers the provisional leader at the end of the final matchday. The decision was later revoked by the Court of Arbitration for Sport, restoring Inter Kashi as champion.

"We played our last I-League match on April 6 (3-1 against Rajasthan United), and our instinct was clear that we had won the title. Our management assured us that we were right, both on and off the pitch," said captain Sumeet Passi.

But the deadlock between the AIFF and Football Sports Development Limited (FSDL) — the body that owns the league — kept pushing the competition further